

COMMUNITY BIRTH CENTRE FOR GALWAY

Public Consultation Summary Report

Compiled from survey and in-person event feedback, October to November 2026

Prepared by Joan Hampton on behalf of the Community Birth Centre Working Group

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1. OVERVIEW

The public consultation ran from 10 October 2026 (in-person event at Galway City Hall) through 31 October 2026 (online survey). A total of 847 survey responses were received. Approximately 210 people attended the in-person event. All responses are anonymised. The full dataset is held separately.

2. SURVEY DEMOGRAPHICS

Respondents by county	Count
Galway city	411 (48.5%)
Galway county (non-city)	298 (35.2%)
Mayo	63 (7.4%)
Roscommon	41 (4.8%)
Clare	22 (2.6%)
Other or not stated	12 (1.4%)

Respondents by connection to maternity services	Count
Pregnant at time of survey	89 (10.5%)
Had a baby in the past 5 years	387 (45.7%)
Healthcare professional	112 (13.2%)
Community or advocacy interest, no direct personal maternity experience	259 (30.6%)

3. SUPPORT FOR THE PROPOSAL

Response	Count
Strong support	471 (55.6%)
Support	282 (33.3%)
Neutral	61 (7.2%)
Some concerns	24 (2.8%)
Opposed	9 (1.1%)
Total support or strong support	88.9 percent

4. KEY THEMES FROM OPEN-TEXT RESPONSES

Theme 1: Continuity of Carer

The most frequently mentioned theme was the desire to know the midwife attending the birth. 382 responses mentioned continuity of carer in some form.

"My community midwife was wonderful throughout my pregnancy. She was not there for the birth. That is the one thing I would change."

"I drove to Cork for my birth centre experience. It was worth it. I should not have had to leave Galway."

Theme 2: Labour Ward Pressure

217 responses mentioned the pressure on UHGs labour ward or described experiences of long waits, changes in care team, or feeling unseen during a busy ward.

"The labour ward is stretched. I could see that when I was there. Giving lower-risk families another option just makes sense."

Theme 3: Safety and Transfer

104 responses raised concerns about safety in an emergency. 89 of those respondents indicated they were reassured by the explanation of the transfer protocol.

"I was worried about emergencies but the transfer time is shorter than I thought. 15 minutes is fine."

Theme 4: Rural Access

63 respondents from outside Galway city raised questions about access and noted they would welcome a centre that reduced their current travel distance to UHG.

Theme 5: Support from Healthcare Professionals

Of the 112 healthcare professional respondents, 98 expressed support. 8 expressed concerns, mostly about workforce implications. 6 were neutral.

5. IN-PERSON EVENT FEEDBACK

The in-person event on 10 October attracted approximately 210 attendees. Written feedback cards were collected from 148 of these. Overall sentiment mirrored the survey.

A consultant obstetrician asked whether the working group had modelled transfer rates for nulliparous women. Joan Hampton responded with the Birthplace in England data (36 to 44 percent for freestanding units) and confirmed this was accounted for in the workforce model and transfer protocol.

A GP from Tuam asked about GP referral pathways. The working group confirmed that the formal service development proposal would include a referral protocol document.

6. CONCLUSIONS

The consultation demonstrates strong and consistent public support for the proposed birth centre. Safety concerns, where raised, were largely addressed by clear explanation of the transfer protocol. The rural access theme suggests the centre could serve a wider catchment than Galway city alone, and site selection should reflect this.

The working group recommends: proceeding to a formal service development proposal; including a rural access section in site assessment criteria; and publishing this summary report and distributing it to the HSE West maternity services steering group.

Full dataset available from joan.hampton@Finthesiss.ai on request.